

UMBRA

a reverie

Rastko Novaković

Onto the hiss in her ears the old imperial time comes slow, the sword and god. What sits around your ankle is the reminder: Know your place. It's very much you. The kind of problem she is can't be solved. She's been deferred, warehoused, and the ether will testify. They used to type up reports with an indigo sheet between the pages, and before there was the black ash of the stake. These are the colours which look back at her when she looks at the obsidian surface of her phone. The trouble smells like roses, long after they've been cut. Is that where you really want to be, pressed in among the ants. Then restless, watching the stone travel along the hopscotch which bends past the old Nippon Cherry tree, the girls always going faster as they slap their bare feet on the concrete. Those were summers, in the old country and the old century. Unbounded, sleeping in the fields, in cars, dozing in cemeteries, mostly alone. Hard to imagine now the same feet going where they wanted. Roaming in packs, under the (so much higher) high sky, all freckles, beer and benzos, looking in on the street betting, the dusty buses with refugees, the exact corner where this or that marauder had bled to death, whodunit? You could sit under the linden trees and hear the news of the killings filter through the windows of the hacks' watering holes, layered by their many theories, the cussing, and slurring pococurantism.

A short novel

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